



Cornell University

Cornell University
395 Pine Tree Road, Suite 130
Ithaca, NY 14850
(607) 255-3936

Farhana Shahid

7/20/2026

Dear Farhana,

I am pleased to tell you that you have been awarded a Graduate Research Assistantship (GRA) for the period 08/21/26-01/05/27.

Appointing Unit: Information Science

Supervisory Name and Email: Vashistha, Aditya, av567@cornell.edu

Funding Source: NSF 188221 Vashistha Career

Standard or Partial Appointment?: This is a standard GRA appointment. In addition to full-time academic progress, service-related duties will be 15 hours/week on average, with no week exceeding 20 hours of work.

Pay Rate: \$2,058.8

Assistantship Pay Rates are described here: <https://gradschool.cornell.edu/financial-support/stipend-rates/>.

Pay Schedule and First Paycheck Date: Semi-monthly <https://gradschool.cornell.edu/financial-support/stipend-rates-receiving-your-stipend/>

Required Duties: The supervisor may clarify or adjust duties, as needed.

Mandatory Training - If Known: Supervisors may schedule orientation and training within the first days of the appointment, and as needed thereafter.

Work Location: Ithaca

Work Modality: All GRA appointments are in-person, unless alternate arrangements are approved by the supervisor.

Work Schedule (if known): Contact Supervisor

Travel Budget: N/A

This contract is subject to the rights afforded to Graduate Student Workers by the CGSU-UE Local 300 Union contract that can be found at <https://cornellgradunion.org/>.

As a Graduate Student Worker, you have three options regarding union membership: (1) become a union member and pay membership dues, (2) choose not to join and pay agency fees, or (3) if you have a sincerely held religious belief, as defined by the U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission ("EEOC") that prevents you from joining and maintaining membership in a union, you may elect to pay an equivalent amount to an approved charity. For complete details on union security and membership, please refer to Article 3 of the CGSU-UE Local 300 Union contract above.

The required FERPA communication and information about the FERPA Release Form is provided in the attached Appendix.

Time commitment: Because this assistantship is in support of your academic and dissertation research as a full-time student, the time spent on research connected with the project and this assistantship is expected to be significant.

The non-academic, service-related components of your assistantship responsibilities shall not exceed 20 hours in any week with the average to be 15 hours per week, counting across all weeks in the appointment period. Hours spent beyond these limits must primarily be associated with degree progress.

If you are unable to complete your duties within this allotted time, you must promptly inform your supervisor.

Stipend and Financial support: This assistantship includes the semi-monthly stipend noted above for the appointment period and support for tuition and the student health plan. You will be responsible for payment of the required graduate student activity fee. The Cornell student health plan provides coverage during the period of this appointment. This coverage can be [extended](#) if you should cease to be enrolled as a graduate student. Individuals who leave the university or are not funded by the university during an academic semester must pay the health plan premium for that period.

You will be paid on a semi-monthly basis, usually on the 15th day and in the last week of each month. Your first and last stipend payments may be partial payments if they fall within (not at the start or end of) semi-monthly periods. Cornell encourages students to set up direct deposit in Workday (<https://hr.cornell.edu/>). All assistantship stipends are subject to state and federal taxation. The tuition portion of the award is not taxed.

Holidays: GRAs are provided all university holidays that occur during their appointment period. These include Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving, and the following day, and Winter Break (typically six working days between December 25 through January 1). If you are required to perform assistantship duties on a university holiday, you must be notified in advance and provisions must be made for you to receive equivalent time off on a non-holiday weekday. Days on which classes are not in session but the university is open (e.g., institutionally-scheduled breaks from classes in Fall Semester, January intersession, or Spring Semester) are not automatic vacation time nor holidays for graduate students appointed on assistantships, but you may request in advance to take vacation during these times.

Vacation Time: In addition to university holidays, graduate students who are on funded appointments (assistantship or fellowship) for the calendar year (August 21-August 20) are eligible for up to 12 days of vacation per year, or if on funded appointments for a portion of the year vacation eligibility is prorated. Vacation time is intended to provide time away from assistantship and academic responsibilities. Vacation time should not interfere with time-sensitive research duties, without the agreement of your supervisor. It is your responsibility to coordinate such time away with the approval of your assistantship supervisor and special committee chair. You will receive instructions on how to track and record vacation time. Vacation time may not be rolled over or accumulated across multiple years, nor will there be any payout of unused vacation time.

Sick Leave: Graduate assistants are eligible for sick leave. Full details of the policy are <https://gradschool.cornell.edu/financial-support/assistantships/time-away-from-assistantship-duties/>.

Performance and Renewal: Assistantship support is a form of student financial support. Continued funding is therefore contingent upon academic performance constituting good standing in your graduate field and satisfactory fulfillment of any teaching or research responsibilities as defined by your assistantship supervisor. Assistantship standards are posted here: <https://gradschool.cornell.edu/financial-support/assistantships/>. Your supervisor may set additional expectations. GRA performance may be documented in the Student Progress Review (SPR).

Acceptance: If you accept this appointment and its conditions (please consult University Policy 1.3, Graduate Student Assistantships for further details), please sign and return a copy of this within ten (10) days.

Please contact your assistantship supervisor as soon as possible to discuss the plans for the assignment so that you have a common understanding of assistantship requirements. If you have not yet completed the Employment Eligibility Verification Form I-9, you will receive separate instructions on how to do so.

Congratulations on being selected for this assistantship. If you have any questions, feel free to contact me. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Sincerely,

Susan Fussell

Director of Graduate Studies

FERPA Notification and Authorization Requirements:

As a Graduate Student Worker at Cornell University, you are represented by CGSU-UE Local 300, your exclusive bargaining representative for terms and conditions of employment. To effectively represent you, the Union may need access to certain information that may be protected under the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA).

To address this, you will be required to complete a FERPA Release Form as part of your onboarding process in Workday (this will appear first in an email and can also be viewed in your Workday notification center). You may also access [The Form Here](#).

This form will:

- Allow you to choose whether to waive your FERPA privacy rights for Union representational purposes
- Provide you the option to decline waiving these rights
- Explain how you can modify your selection in the future

If you waive your FERPA rights, the Union:

- Will only use the information for representational purposes
- Must obtain your consent before sharing information with any other party
- Will only receive information to which they are entitled under the National Labor Relations Act

You may rescind your permission at any time by providing the University with a written revocation of the consent addressed to:

Staff and Labor Relations

391 Pine Tree Road
Ithaca, NY 14850
Email: staff-labor-relations@cornell.edu

The FERPA Release Form will be available in your Workday notifications center and provided to you to your Cornell email, and must be completed before the start of your appointment. Please note that this is a required component of the onboarding process.

If you have any questions about this notice, the FERPA Release Form and/or how the information shared with the union may be used, please contact Staff and Labor Relations at staff-labor-relations@cornell.edu or communications@cgsu.org.